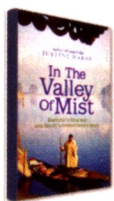


Lost in the MIST

Kashmir vanishes from this dramatised version of the tragedy in the post-'80s Valley

| By Omair Ahmad |



IN THE VALLEY OF MIST: KASHMIR'S LONG WAR: ONE FAMILY'S EXTRAORDINARY STORY

by JUSTINE HARDY
Random House
Price: £12.99
Pages: 271

There is a story, possibly apocryphal, about a celebrity intellectual who flew to a conference in New York after having spent two days on a houseboat. "I've just come from Kashmir," she gushed to a star-struck audience, who accepted her expertise completely as she told them how it all was.

Justine Hardy's immensely readable memoir, *In the Valley of Mist*, is thankfully much more than that. She uses her decades spent flitting in and out of Kashmir to gather a lot of material. She also addresses another issue. Until very recently, most books about Kashmir suffered from a curious problem: they didn't contain Kashmiris. Instead they were filled with statistics, dates and documents with a light seasoning of history. Hardy uses the family of Mohammed Dar, "patriarch, husband, son, houseboat-owner, carpet-seller, aid-worker and conservationist" to bring out the human face of the dramatic changes that have taken place since the late 1980s. There is a supporting cast ranging from a tailor, to a *mukhbir*, to a local journalist, all the way to The General, but the Dars are the main characters of the story.

In a sense, Hardy could have hardly chosen better. The Dars are rich and powerful enough to host young men who will go on to be the current mirwaiz (chief priest) and chief minister

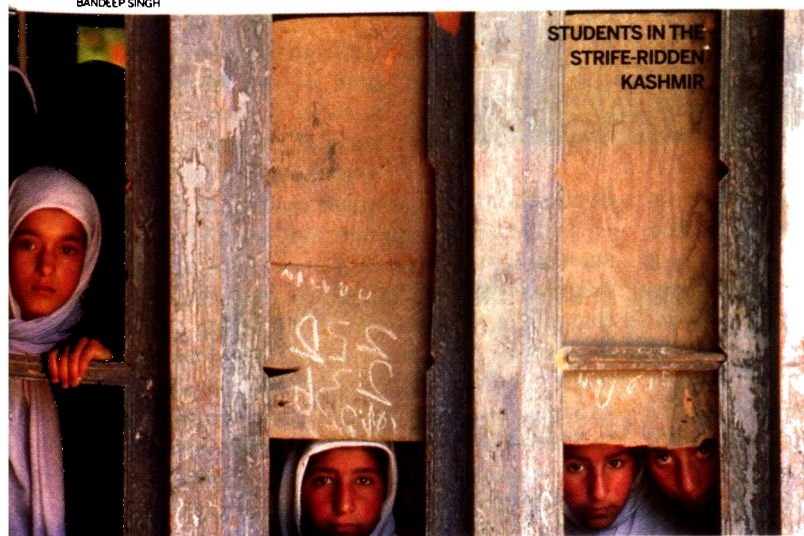
of the Valley for an Eid meal. Mohammed Dar has sold carpets to Hillary Clinton. His family is rich enough to not be corrupt, an immense luxury in the Valley. Instead, they tell her about officials who build buildings that don't exist, and whose successors then charge the government to pull down structures that were built with "substandard material", which is true since they only existed on paper.

This perspective allows her to narrate the harrowing tale of how masked men in camouflage burst into the Dars' house in the dead of the night, ransacking everything at the point of the gun, while the family could do nothing, the patriarch reading the Quran until the attackers were finished. Later when one of his sons applies for a British visa, he is refused. "It was as though the interviewer... had seen into Arshad's heart. Of course, he could not have known of the attack... but he had seen the young man's vulnerability, his wide-open heart that was looking to escape from the place that was so full of pain for him." It also allows her to movingly convey how the 2005 earthquake affected people in Kashmir, how quickly it slipped from the headlines, and the reality of how aid works with the NGOs, military, and locals behaving in often counter-intuitive ways.

Yet at the same time this narrow perspective is the book's biggest flaw. The Dars are extremely atypical of Kashmiris at large. The children go to England to study, not one of them has been lost to either the bullets of militants or the military. Their lives in Srinagar are very different from the villages, from where incidentally, most militants are recruited. Not from Café Arabica where a local journalist explains that militancy was all about making a few bucks. Hardy could have moved out of this charmed circle, gone to Ganpathyar in Srinagar itself to see the claustrophobic conditions where the few remaining Kashmiri Pandit families live. She could have visited Sopore, the town at the heart of the insurgency, where trash lines the river and a broken water filter treatment plant means that filthy water comes from the government taps.

Hardy writes beautifully, and her anecdotes are telling, but as for the Valley, a large section of it seems to have been lost in the mist. ■

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